We don't teach only public speaking and debating. They are very important ingredients of communication. At SpeakSmart, we try to teach communication more as a life skill.

So that means of course you could debate, of course you could stand on stage and do a public speech, but we will handle all the formats. So that means when a child comes to SpeakSmart and a few years later you meet the they should be able to handle not only debate and public speaking, they should be able to deal with the business negotiation, they should be able to interview well, they should be able to persuade their mother that they want a cell phone or they want to spend time out with their friends, they should be able to tell an interesting story in a way that people listen and that is the way that they should be able to handle every format of communication. Even if a reporter comes up and what are your comments on this? So they should be able to understand every format and respond accordingly.

I mean what in your opinion if I asked you that you know in say communication there are four C's. There's you know there's confidence, there's clarity, there's content and there's connectivity. So which one would you say is the most important? Ma'am I think all of them.

Yes you're right. So all of them are very important ingredients of communication. However at SpeakSmart we like to think that the fourth one connectivity is a little bit more important than others because when we are talking about effective communication let me use an example.

So your daughter has come home from school and you're confident with your communication. You're very clear what you have to say and your content is in place because you know exactly what are the things you require her to do. But if you've not factored in the fact that maybe she's had a bad day, maybe she messed up a test, maybe she didn't get selected for something and you're trying to tell her all these important things with great clarity at that point of time, do you think she's about to do your bidding? She won't even listen after a while I think ma'am.

So this is what effective communication is about Vishakha is when you communicate in a way that is a little bit more focused on your end objective. So in debate the end objective would be to persuade your audience with your logic and your clarity, you develop an argument but also to heckle the opponent. In a conversation you want to give a person the feeling that yes I've got you, I kind of understand your point of view but I don't quite agree with you.

In a story maybe you say it in a way that everybody should be excited to listen to you. If suddenly a reporter comes up to you, you should be able to talk in a short succinct bite which is attractive for TV because unlike that like say for instance in a panel discussion you would use authenticity, you would use life examples because that's what a panel discussion is about. But on TV even if all of that is true, if you try to tell them too much they'll simply switch the channel because it's boring, people just do not have the bandwidth.

So in effective communication it's essentially a more goal-focused communication which would of course include the ingredients of clarity and confidence and content but it would seek to make a connection and most importantly keep that long-term objective in mind. For instance if a student got undermarked in a test and his teacher gave different marks, he got a 4 on 10 and somebody else got a 10 on 10 and or an 8 on 10 and the teacher marked them differently. So your objective may be to say you could just go up and say ma'am look I mean what happened here, I mean this is not quite correct.

So in which case you haven't thought about your larger objective focused on the fact that she is wrong and you are right but is that your ultimate objective? If your ultimate objective is to get the marks from her, perhaps your communication might change then maybe you'd observe whether she's in a good mood before you go up to her and say ma'am would you take a look perhaps I made a mistake, can't quite follow what you're doing but you know what happened here, would you take a look because my friend seems to have got similar marks and not sure why what happened and she would perhaps be in a better frame of mind to listen to you and grant to your marks. So here at speak smart we genuinely believe that this objective focused communication is very important. Now let me step that example up a little further.

Say you take two doctors okay or two businessmen equally qualified and or owning equally big businesses. So these two doctors may be very good with their skill set but if they're unable to talk or communicate properly with the patient or with the hospital management where do you think their careers would be in 10 years time or with the businessman with exactly you know the same business structure if they are not handling their employees well if they

do not know how to maybe when invited on television or for a panel discussion talk about their company in a way that makes sense which sounds more service oriented rather than maybe focus on profits how do you think it would kind of play out years down the line. So therefore we genuinely believe here that effective communication is a life skill which will help you not only to focus on your goals but ultimately optimize life no matter what you know qualifications you have.

Let me just share with you so our plan would normally look like we take a topic and you know we take a structure around it so one day like I said one day could be debate another day could be a panel discussion another day could be just doing a skit and then trying to share a message another day could be a campaign as an activist another day could be creating an advertisement. So what we do is we really believe that creativity isn't born out of a vacuum. So initially we initiate the topic and around it we definitely teach them how to use their body how to use their voice also how to use their vocabulary and vocabulary for us means something totally different from how it is commonly understood because vocabulary doesn't mean just using very big words vocabulary simply means to speak in a way that your communication is effective okay so you've got to have a sense of the audience and speak according to their understanding modify your speech use illustrations be graphic kind of grab their attention and do whatever is required in your speech to do that it's not just about having a large set of words which people don't understand to make yourself hurt that's not the way it works here.

I mean another common question that I get is about the student teacher ratio or whether we give homework and I'm going to answer both of these so usually our class strength would be you know about we'd have about 10 students to a teacher and usually we'd have more than one teacher in the room because our main objective here is to make sure that every single class every student is given the opportunity to speak and why is that so because effective speaking or communication is a very practical subject so imagine if I was trying to teach you football and I took a ball showed it to you did 10 demonstrations and explained the entire game to you would you actually learn football Vishaka till you kicked a ball you would similarly even if we encapsulated all the rules and taught them everything that we knew no student is going to learn until they participate in the process so students will speak we'll have an objective for them and they will address that format they will give each other feedback this teacher will also assess their skill set and after every class we're going to share a video with the parents so that you have some context and you see you know how your child is participating in class also we don't quite believe in giving homework so usually you know every single class is like a performance around the topic and they would finish whatever they have to and make their presentation in class sometimes they speak as individuals often they speak as teams and also in the team you know they learn to manage the team they learn leadership they learn to look out for each other and work with each other which is also a very important skill set and it's great because we have students from different classes different schools different skill sets so when you present as a team you've got to keep all of that in mind to really beat the other team